
Seasonal Calendar

*Pine Lake & North Lake — the whole year
on one sheet*

Which fish, which month, which depth, which spot

Fish do not follow the calendar; they follow water temperature, and the calendar is only a rough proxy for it. A cold spring pushes everything two weeks late. Use the temperature column, not the month, whenever you can measure it.

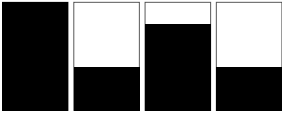
The year by species

Species	Activity by month	Peak periods and where
Largemouth bass	Activity levels: Jan (low), Feb (low), Mar (low), Apr (medium), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (medium-high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium), Dec (low).	May–Jun shallow, pre-spawn and spawn: Pine 6, 7; North 1, 7. Sep–Oct feeding hard on the weed edge: Pine 5; North 1.
Smallmouth bass	Activity levels: Jan (low), Feb (low), Mar (low), Apr (medium), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (low).	May–Jun on gravel: Pine 2, 4. Oct the best of the year: Pine 3, 4; North 4.
Walleye	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (high), Dec (medium).	Oct–Nov on the breaks: Pine 3, 4, 8; North 3, 4. Dawn and dusk all year.
Northern pike	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (high), Apr (high), May (medium-high), Jun (medium-high), Jul (medium), Aug (medium), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (high), Dec (medium).	Apr post-spawn in the shallows and Oct–Nov feeding up: Pine 1, 9; North 2, 6.
Bluegill	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium), Dec (medium-high).	Late May–Jun on the beds: Pine 6; North 1. Deep weed edge after.
Pumpkinseed	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium), Dec (medium).	Same beds as bluegill, slightly shallower and tighter to cover.
Black crappie	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (medium), Apr (high), May (high), Jun (medium-high), Jul (medium-high), Aug (medium-high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (medium-high), Dec (high).	May near brush and Jan through the ice. Dusk always.
Yellow perch	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (high), Mar (high), Apr (high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (high), Aug (high), Sep (high), Oct (high), Nov (high), Dec (high).	Dec–Feb the best perch fishing of the year, on the 15–30 ft flats. Daylight only.
Rock bass	Activity levels: Jan (medium), Feb (medium), Mar (medium), Apr (medium-high), May (high), Jun (high), Jul (high), Aug (high), Sep (high), Oct (medium-high), Nov (medium), Dec (medium).	Jun–Aug on any rock. The reliable summer fish for a child.
Cisco	Activity levels: Jan (high), Feb (medium), Mar (low), Apr (low), May (low), Jun (low), Jul (low), Aug (low), Sep (low), Oct (medium), Nov (high), Dec (high).	Nov–Dec spawning shallow; through the ice in Jan . Pine Lake only.

The year by water temperature

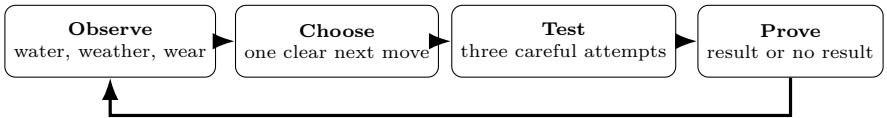
Water	Roughly	What is happening, and what to do
32–40 °F	Dec–Mar	Ice. Panfish in the bays, perch on the flats, pike on tip-ups over weed edges. Everything moves slowly; small baits, long pauses.
40–45 °F	Late Mar–Apr	Ice-out. Pike spawn in flooded shallows — the first fish to go. Walleye follow onto rock. Fish the north and west shorelines, which warm first.
45–55 °F	Apr–early May	Walleye spawn and then feed. Crappie push into bays. Slow presentations, live bait, dark bottoms that hold heat.
55–65 °F	May–early Jun	Bass spawn , largemouth first and smallmouth just after. Bass season opens the first Saturday in May. The single best window of the year for numbers of fish, shallow.
65–72 °F	Jun	Panfish spawn on colonial beds. Everything is shallow and visible. This is the month to take children.
72–80 °F	Jul–Aug	The lake stratifies. Fish split: some hold the deep weed edge, some go to the hard structure, and on Pine some suspend over the basin following cisco. Fish early, late, and deep.
72–60 °F	Sep	Turnover. The surface cools, the layers mix, and for one to two weeks the fishing is genuinely poor and the water may look cloudy. Wait it out.
60–45 °F	Oct–Nov	The best fishing of the year. Big fish feed heavily and move onto structure. Larger baits, and do not be afraid to fish the middle of the day.
45–33 °F	Nov–Dec	Deep and slow. Then first ice, which is often excellent — and the most dangerous ice of the season.

Times of day

		
Dawn	The most reliable hour on both lakes for almost everything. Non-negotiable in July and August.	
Midday	Perch and rock bass feed; most predators do not. Bright calm midday is when finesse presentations earn their keep, <i>see the wacky rig sheet</i> and <i>see the drop-shot sheet</i> .	
Dusk	The best hour for walleye and crappie. Be on the spot before the light goes rather than arriving with it.	
Night	Walleye and big pike keep feeding; panfish shut down entirely.	
Weather	A falling barometer ahead of a front turns fish on hard. The day after a cold front passes is the worst day of any week — go deeper, slow down, and downsize.	
Wind	Wind on a point or a bar concentrates plankton, then baitfish, then predators. Fish the windy shore, not the comfortable one.	

Season dates change every year. On these waters in 2026–27, gamefish open 2 May and bass, walleye and pike close 7 March; musky is open water only through 31 December; panfish are open all year. Confirm with the Wisconsin DNR before every trip.

Use a closed-loop check



Question	Check	Recovery
What changed?	Name one visible or measurable fact: wind direction, depth, water temperature, abrasion, knot shape, lure track, fish reflex, or elapsed time.	If you cannot name the change, observe for one minute before changing equipment.
What am I testing?	Change one variable only and state what success will look like before the attempt.	Restore the last known setup; avoid changing lure, depth, speed, and location together.
Is the system sound?	Trace the full chain from hand to fish: line, knot, leader, hook, drag, handling tool, route home.	Stop on any rough line, crossed wrap, open snap, dull point, missing tool, or unsafe condition; repair or leave.
What proves completion?	A repeatable result and a final tactile/visual check, not merely finishing the written steps.	Repeat slowly under good light. If the check is ambiguous, treat it as a failure.

Final proof before the next cast

Say the plan in one sentence. Tug-test the terminal connection, touch-check the last two feet of line, confirm hook point and snap closure, set the drag, and identify the safe landing and release route. If weather, visibility, footing, or fish condition makes that route doubtful, change the plan before casting.

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